

Black bean and plantain salad

This is a very hearty salad featuring plantains, which are a starchy, mild type of banana used predominately in Latin American cuisine. As an ingredient, plantains might compare to America's potato. They must be cooked and are not eaten raw, which is why they are also referred to as *cooking bananas*. The salad's **lively** flavor and aroma make an appealing presentation.

½ pound (1 cup) dried black beans [180g]

1 cup long-grain white rice [200g]

1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

6 tablespoons vegetable oil

2 plantains, peeled and cut diagonally into ¼-inch [.5-cm] slices

1 large red bell pepper, cut into ½-inch [1-cm] dice

1 fresh jalapeño pepper, seeded and minced

3 garlic cloves, minced

1½ tablespoons cumin seeds

2 tablespoons unrefined sugar cane

2 to 3 tablespoons extra virgin oil

6 tablespoons lime juice

¼ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [60ml]

Hot sauce

1. Place the beans in a large saucepan and add enough cold water to cover by 2 inches [5cm]. Let stand 6 to 8 hours or overnight. **Drain**, return the beans to the pan, and cover them with fresh water. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook until the beans are tender but not falling apart, 45 to 60 minutes. Drain and rinse under cold running water until cool. Drain well.
2. In a medium saucepan, **cook** the rice in 2 cups [500ml] lightly salted water, covered, until the rice is tender and liquid is absorbed, 15 to 18 minutes. Transfer the cooked rice to a large bowl and fluff with a fork. Season with ½ teaspoon of the salt and ⅛ teaspoon of the pepper.

3. **Heat** the vegetable oil in a large heavy skillet, preferably cast-iron, over medium-high heat. Add the plantain slices, in batches if necessary, and fry, pressing down gently with a spatula from time to time, until golden brown on both sides, about 2 to 3 minutes. Reduce the heat slightly if the plantains brown too quickly. Drain on paper towels and sprinkle with salt. Pour all but 2 tablespoons oil from the pan.
4. Add the bell pepper to the skillet and sauté over medium-high heat until softened and slightly browned around the edges, 3 to 4 minutes. **Add** the jalapeño pepper, garlic, cumin seeds, and sugar and sauté 1 minute longer, stirring constantly.
5. Add the cooked beans, fried plantains, and sautéed pepper mixture to the rice. Add the olive oil, lime juice, and cilantro. Mix well. **Season** with additional salt and pepper to taste. Serve at room temperature. Pass a bottle of hot sauce on the side.

SERVES 6

